



Crossing times: Temporal boundary-spanning practices in interorganizational projects

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Abstract

This paper introduces the notion of “temporal boundary spanning” and highlights the key role of project management in resolving temporal tensions among partners participating in interorganizational projects (IOPs). The present study, which is based on data from 93 IOPs undertaken within a major change program, relies on in-depth, semi-structured interviews, observations, and detailed analyses of written documents and procedures from those IOPs. Based on the data, we inductively develop a practice-based theory that identifies three main practices (framing, synchronizing, hyping) used to resolve the central temporal tensions observed in the studied IOPs. In that respect, the paper offers novel insights into the role and practice of project management in IOPs.

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1. Introduction

In the last few decades, the number and depth of collaborations across organizations (Ebers, 1997) aimed at realizing complex products, systems, and services has surged (Hobday, 2000). This development, which is evident in a range of industries and regions (Grabher, 2004; Jones and Lichtenstein, 2007; Maurer, 2010), has spurred a plethora of activities that are organized and coordinated through various kinds of interorganizational projects (IOPs). Such projects may be launched with the goal of developing new products and services, changing organizational routines, or building organizational capabilities across organizations.

Despite their popularity, IOPs entail fundamental challenges, especially as they require intense cooperation and coordination among actors from various sectors and institutional domains with disparate interests, professional identities, and organizational procedures (Dille and Söderlund, 2011; O'Mahony and Bechky, 2008). These actors are immersed in

diverse permanent and temporal structures from which they draw when performing their daily work (Orlikowski and Yates, 2002). These structures intersect in IOPs, which often leads to goal conflicts, contractual disagreements, and a need for ongoing negotiation and coordination within the focal project in relation to dividing tasks and activities, and ensuring accurate communication among the actors involved. Prior research has highlighted the many and varied problems associated with efforts to establish cooperation and coordination arrangements that are acceptable to all parties involved in IOPs (see, e.g., Flyvbjerg, 2017; Manning, 2017).

As IOPs involve diverse sets of actors and organizations, cross-boundary interactions require the presence of common ground to facilitate knowledge integration; overcome differences with regard to cultures, languages, perspectives, and understandings (Bechky, 2003; Lenfle and Söderlund, 2018; Vijk et al., 2008); and solve numerous coordination-related issues (Mors, 2010). Furthermore, given their set deadlines (Lindkvist et al., 1998) and task-related interdependencies (Thompson, 1967), IOPs are likely to be characterized by conflicting pressures and priorities, as they involve actors and organizations with different temporal understandings and

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